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Virginia House of Delegates Floor Session, Joint Assembly, Monday, January 19, 2026

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- Official floor video (House of Delegates archive, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NU3RkDC6tKU
- LIS House minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/H

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-16. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:04:27] House will come to order. House will be eighties. House will come to order. Sergeant at Arms.

[00:10:18] Mr. Speaker, the Senate of Virginia. The members of the House will rise and receive the Senate of

[00:10:23] Virginia. The Joint Assembly will come to order. Clerk of the Senate will call the roll of the

[00:11:37] Senate. Senator Ayer, Senator Bagby, Senator Boisco, Senator Carol Foy, Senator Cyphers, Senator Craig, Senator Deeds, Senator Deesteph, Senator Diggs, Senator Durant, Senator Eben, Senator Favola, Senator French, Senator Hackworth, Senator Head, Senator Jones, Senator Jordan,

[00:12:17] Senator Locke, Senator Lucas, Senator Marsden, Senator McDougall, Senator McPike, Senator Mulcahy, Senator Obenshain, Senator Peake, Senator Bukarski, Senator Perry, Senator Pillian, Senator Reeves, Senator Roan, Senator Rouse, Senator Salim, Senator Cindy Vassin, Senator

[00:12:47] Stanley, Senator Stewart, Senator Sturdivant, Senator Suterlein, Senator Cerevelle, Senator Van Valkenburg, Senator Williams-Graves.

[00:13:05] You have a quorum, Madam President. Mr. President, whatever. Sergeant in Arms, get her out of here. No, I'm joking. The members of the House will indicate their presence on the electronic voting board.

[00:13:44] We'll close the roll.

[00:14:01] Mr. President, a quorum is present. Clerk will report a resolution. Resolution, Joint Assembly, notifying the governor of organization. Resolve the president of the Joint Assembly appointed committee of 10, opposed to six delegates, four senators to notify the governor that the Joint Assembly is duly organized and will be pleased to receive her and any communication she may desire to make.

[00:14:21] As many as favor adoption of the resolution will say aye. Those opposed will say no. The resolution is agreed to. The clerk will announce the committee to notify the governor that the General Assembly is ready to receive her and hear any remarks she wishes to make. Mr. President appoints the following members to notify the governor and escort her to the Joint Assembly.

[00:14:37] Delegates Herring, Tran, Torian, Watts, Kilgore, and Kent, as well as Senators Lucas, Locke, Cerevelle, and McDougall. The Joint Assembly will be at ease.

[00:17:38] Mr. President, entering from the gallery, the first gentleman of the Commonwealth and his party. The Joint Assembly will receive the first gentleman of the Commonwealth and his party.

[00:17:48] Sergeant in Arms. Mr. President, the Governor's Cabinet and other Executive Branch officials.

[00:18:58] The Joint Assembly will receive the Governor's Cabinet and other Executive Branch officials.

[00:19:16] Sergeant in Arms. Mr. President, the Chairman and Commissioners of the State Corporation Commission.

[00:19:53] The Joint Assembly will receive the Chairman and Commissioners of the State Corporation Commission. Sergeant in Arms. Mr. President, the Chief Justice and Justices of the Supreme Court.

[00:20:16] The Joint Assembly will receive the Chief Justice and Justices of the Supreme Court.

[00:20:20] Sergeant at Arms. Mr. President, the Attorney General of Virginia. The Joint Assembly will receive the Attorney General of Virginia. The Joint Assembly and guests will please be seated. The Joint Assembly will be at ease. The Joint Assembly will come to order. Sergeant at Arms. Mr. President, Her Excellency, the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:29:13] The members will receive the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:31:42] Kay, Joint Assembly and guests, please be seated. As Speaker of the House of Delegates and President of the Joint Assembly, it is my pleasure to present to you, Her Excellency, the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia, the Honorable Abigail Davis Spanberg.

[00:32:04] Mr. Speaker, Madam Lieutenant Governor, Madam President Pro Temp,

[00:32:55] Members of the General Assembly, Mr. Attorney General, Justices of the Supreme Court, members of the Cabinet, our clerks, honored guests, and most importantly, our fellow Virginians.

[00:33:13] Two days ago, we celebrated an inauguration, the peaceful transfer of power that has defined Virginia for 250 years. On Saturday afternoon, I spoke about the urgent need to unite for a common purpose. Amid a national moment too often defined by chaos, our fellow citizens are anxious about the future.

[00:33:35] And today, that work, the work of governing and providing stability begins in earnest. Thank you for your time this afternoon. It is an honor to stand before you as the 75th governor. And with us today

in the gallery is the first first gentleman.

[00:33:54] Neither of us could have imagined we'd end up here, but I'm grateful to be taking on this adventure together. Adam, thank you for your willingness to serve Virginia in this new role.

[00:34:29] As you know, the Constitution of Virginia requires the governor to report on the state of the Commonwealth once a year. I've had this job for a little over 48 hours, so bear with me. In all seriousness, it is nearly impossible to step into Thomas Jefferson's capital and not feel the weight of our shared history. Generations of Virginians have stood in this building, have shaped the course of our Commonwealth, and written the history of America. And this week, we added new chapters to that history. Just yesterday, Chief Justice Cleopal, the first

[00:35:07] African-American woman to lead the Supreme Court of Virginia in our Commonwealth's history, swore in new members of our cabinet. Our fellow Virginians are also now served by two other history-making public servants. Lieutenant Governor Ghazala Hashmi, the first Muslim woman

[00:35:25] elected to statewide office anywhere in the country, as well as Virginia's first elected

[00:35:51] African-American Attorney General, Jay Jones. And in the incoming class of delegates seated in this chamber right now, there are a record 42 women serving in the House of Delegates.

[00:36:20] These milestones belong to all Virginians, no matter our political affiliation.

[00:36:45] They are proof that our representative democracy is exactly that, is becoming truly representative. And this progress is thanks to the voters from every corner of this Commonwealth who made their voices heard at the ballot box. And the voters sent us here, each and every one of us, and we must never forget that as we embark on the hard work that we have ahead of us.

[00:37:09] In November, Virginians from across the political spectrum united to build one of the broadest coalitions for change in a generation. They sent a clear, loud, and clear message that they want leaders who will work together to deliver results, and I intend to listen to them.

[00:37:28] People have asked me in recent weeks about the concept of a mandate. What's your mandate? They wonder what the results of November's elections will mean in practice. And here is what I believe. Virginians did not elect me to pursue a particular ideological agenda, nor did they elect me to settle scores or add noise to our politics.

[00:37:50] They did not elect me to grandstand. My mandate is simple, to get things done for Virginia's families, Virginia schools, Virginia businesses, and our communities, period. And if I've learned anything from my previous time in elected office, it's that Virginians want a government that works.

[00:38:25] They want elected leaders who show up, who listen, who work to make their lives a little easier. They want us to address the challenges that are keeping them up at night. That is what I pledge to do for the next four years, and I ask all of you in both parties to join me in that endeavor.

[00:38:45] To the members of the General Assembly, I know what it means to represent your neighbors, to take on the burdens of public scrutiny, to give up time with your family in service to your community. It is no small thing. And whatever differences we may have in the days ahead, I respect the service of each and every one of you, the service that you have chosen to give.

[00:39:09] And this administration is committed to being your partner moving forward. When we work together, Virginia will succeed. It is as simple as that. So let me say this very directly. My door is open to every member of this body, Democrat or Republican. I have always believed that no person and no party has a monopoly on good ideas. That's why I've built an administration that reflects that belief, a cabinet of talented, experienced leaders ready to work alongside all of us.

[00:39:43] They are public servants, and I am grateful to them, the entire cabinet, and our staff that they have answered the call to serve in this capacity at this time. And to the career public servants serving across our Commonwealth, across state departments and state agencies, thank you for everything you do.

[00:40:04] Please understand that I want you and expect you to do your very best work. And I want you to have the right tools and feel supported as you do it. I want you to know that I am grateful for the expertise and the commitment that you bring to serving the citizens of Virginia.

[00:40:24] And we have several state employees joining us in the gallery today.

[00:40:47] Please, if you're a state employee serving our Commonwealth and our communities, please stand. Thank you for your continued service, for the expertise that you bring to your work in our state agencies and departments.

[00:41:19] And it is my expectation that our cabinet secretaries continue to lead with respect and with a focus recognizing the strength of skills and experience that you all bring to bear each and every day. During my time in Congress, I was ranked as the most bipartisan member from Virginia.

[00:41:36] I may have mentioned that one or two times along the campaign trail. And my administration intends to govern the same way, to work together, to deliver for the people of Virginia. And we must do that in order to tackle the most pressing challenges facing our neighbors today, the high cost of living. I want to take a moment to focus on this, because when we talk about affordability, it's important to be clear about what we mean and why it matters. Over the past two years, I've traveled to every corner of the Commonwealth. I've met

[00:42:11] seniors in Southwest struggling to afford their prescription medications, parents in Hampton Roads worried about the rising energy bills, young people in Northern Virginia who want to stay and build their lives here in the Commonwealth, but can't find housing that they can afford. Now, I know there are some who want to dismiss these concerns, some who look at Wall Street and say the economy's doing just fine, some who simply want struggling families to just be patient. Relief is right around the corner. It's going to get a little bit better. Just wait a little bit longer. There are some who have even called affordability a hoax or a con job, and I would invite them to come to Virginia

[00:42:50] and engage with the families and the business leaders that I have met and that I know you all know, because the facts tell a different story. More than 70 percent of Virginians say they can't find housing that they can reasonably afford to rent or buy. Nearly half of college students who graduate from Virginia universities leave our commonwealth within five years. That's above the national average. Prescription drug costs have risen. Energy bills are high. The challenges are real, and my fellow Virginians, this is not a hoax. This is real life, and we cannot be honest.

[00:43:29] If we cannot be honest about a problem, it will be impossible for us to find solutions to it. The truth is that prices have been rising for years, but the economic uncertainty and the instability coming out

of Washington over the past 12 months, particularly for Virginia, have made things undeniably worse, and families are paying the price.

[00:43:55] So what can we do right here in Richmond to make Virginia more affordable? As governor, I cannot wave a magic wand to make prices drop overnight. Believe me, I wish that I could, but there are tangible steps that we can take right now on a state level to make good on our pledge to Virginia families. On Saturday, some of my very first executive actions as governor reflected this mission. Two days ago, I ordered all of my cabinet secretaries and all executive branch agencies to identify where they can reduce costs

[00:44:31] for Virginians, whether that's immediate fixes or longer-term budgetary, regulatory, or policy changes. They must submit these reports within 90 days because we cannot afford to wait. I look

[00:44:45] forward to reviewing the recommendations and putting them into action. I have also directed a comprehensive multi-agency review of regulations and permitting practices that impact our ability

[00:45:17] to build new homes. We need to cut red tape. We need to cut red tape, eliminate burdensome requirements and streamline approvals. We need to get ready to build more housing. And that's why I

[00:45:46] am establishing a commission on unlocking housing production. And when it comes to the cost of health care, we are not waiting around. My administration is establishing a new interagency health financing task force we need to make sure we're spending our health care dollars effectively

[00:46:22] we need to strengthen our health care infrastructure and we need to identify where federal cuts will hurt virginia the most this task force will be entrusted with finding these answers and it will get to work immediately but but executive action alone is not enough to deliver lasting relief we

[00:46:58] We need legislation, and that's why today I am asking the General Assembly to join me in passing our Affordable Virginia Agenda, a legislative package designed to be a first step towards lowering costs for Virginia families in three critical areas: health care, housing, and energy.

[00:47:18] And I want to thank the majority leadership here today for partnering with me on unveiling these proposals. But they are not hyper-partisan proposals. They are common-sense solutions. And I believe they deserve support from every member of this body, Democrats and Republicans.

[00:47:36] So let me walk through what we're proposing. First, on health care, no Virginian should have to choose between filling a prescription and paying for groceries. But that is the reality for far too many families.

[00:48:06] So let's start with prescription drugs. Right now, pharmacy benefit managers, the middlemen known as PBMs, are driving up the cost of medications while pocketing the savings for themselves. They steer patients away from local pharmacies, harming and hurting rural, independently-owned pharmacies.

[00:48:23] They claw back payments from small businesses, and they make it harder for Virginians to afford the medications they need. This has to stop. Our legislation will require that rebates go back to patients, not corporate middlemen.

[00:48:55] And this will protect independent pharmacies from predatory practices. Next, the Affordable Care Act marketplace. At the start of this month, we watched as leaders in Washington sat on their hands and allowed premiums to skyrocket.

[00:49:13] Virginia families simply cannot afford to wait for Congress to act, so we are going to act first. Our proposal will establish targeted premium assistance.

[00:49:44] That way we can keep coverage more affordable for Virginians who are at most at risk of losing it and also benefit all Virginians who buy their insurance. And finally, we need to invest in our health care workforce.

[00:49:59] You cannot see a doctor if there is no doctor to see. And too many communities across Virginia, particularly in rural areas, are facing critical shortages of health care providers. Our legislation will strengthen incentive programs to recruit and retain providers where they are needed most so that every Virginian can access quality, affordable care close to home.

[00:50:34] Virginians are paying far too much to heat and cool our homes.

[00:50:57] And while we cannot control global energy markets, there are things we can do to lower monthly utility bills for Virginia families. We are going to expand energy storage across the Commonwealth. Energy storage allows us to capture cheaper power and use it during peak demand when prices are highest. That means savings for families and a more reliable grid for everyone. We're also going to expand programs that help lower-income Virginians make their homes more energy efficient.

[00:51:29] Simple improvements like better insulation and weatherization can save families hundreds and even thousands of dollars per year. Virginia needs to be more energy independent. That means solar, nuclear, and yes, despite what Washington might have one think, it also means offshore wind.

[00:52:07] As we speak, the Federal Interior Department is attempting to halt offshore wind development across the country, including one of the largest infrastructure projects in Virginia history.

[00:52:36] This is an attack not just on our energy, but on private business. And while I was glad to see the court ruling on Friday that temporarily blocked this action by the federal government, we all know that this battle is far from over.

[00:52:52] This project will create thousands of jobs and generate billions of dollars in economic activity in Hampton Roads. And as governor, I will do everything in my power to make sure that it continues to move forward.

[00:53:26] And if we're talking about energy affordability, let me say here today that the Commonwealth of Virginia is rejoining the Regional Greenhouse Cash Initiative.

[00:53:56] This is about cost savings. Reggie generated hundreds of millions of dollars for Virginia, dollars that went directly to flood mitigation, energy efficiency programs, and lowering bills for Virginia families who need help most. Withdrawing from Reggie did not lower energy costs. We have seen them rise.

[00:54:20] In fact, of course, the opposite has happened. It just took money out of the pockets of Virginians, and so it is time to fix this mistake. Now, the third issue in our affordable Virginia agenda is housing. And this issue is so personal for so many Virginians. Young people who grew up

[00:54:59] here and want to stay here but cannot find an apartment they can afford. Families who have saved for years but still cannot compete in the housing market. Seniors on fixed incomes watching their rent climb higher every year or unable to downsize because they can't buy something else.

[00:55:19] We have a housing shortage in Virginia, and until we address it, prices will keep rising. So here's what we're going to do.

[00:55:43] First, we are going to protect renters. Right now, Virginia law gives tenants just five days to respond after a landlord files to terminate their lease. Five days. That's not enough time to get your next paycheck, let alone find a new place to live.

[00:55:58] Our legislation will extend that window to two weeks, giving families a fair chance to get that paycheck, pay their rent, and stay in their homes. Secondly, we are going to give communities more tools to build affordable housing.

[00:56:31] Not every solution works in every locality. What works in Arlington probably wouldn't work in Acomac. Our proposal will empower local governments to adopt affordable housing programs that fit their needs. because the people closest to the problem are often best positioned to solve it.

[00:56:51] And third, we're going to make it easier to finance the construction of housing that Virginia families can actually afford. Our proposal creates a revolving loan fund to support mixed income developments so that builders have the resources that they need to create homes for working families, not just luxury units.

[00:57:12] Health care, energy, housing, three areas where Virginia families are feeling the squeeze and three areas where we can deliver real relief. These are common sense proposals. They're not about ideology. They're about results. And I'm asking every member of this General Assembly, Democrat or Republican, to work together to put these bills on my desk as soon as possible.

[00:57:52] Because here's the truth. Affordability, it's not just a family budget issue. It's an issue of economic competitiveness. When a Virginia College graduate cannot afford to live near their job, they're going to move to Maryland or Georgia or Texas. And when health care costs rise, small businesses face higher expenses and workers have less money to spend out on the economy.

[00:58:14] When a family can't afford child care, oftentimes a parent drops out of the workforce altogether. If we fail to act on affordability, we risk slower economic growth, lower tax revenue, and declining productivity, consequences that would disadvantage Virginia for decades to come.

[00:58:34] So make no mistake about it, we are competing against 49 other states for the best talent in the United States of America and the businesses that follow that talent. If we do not act, we will lose out in that competition. And on my watch as governor, I do not intend to lose.

[00:58:55] I intend for Virginia to dominate.

[00:58:59] So we have some work to do. Recent data indicate that in 2025, Virginia saw more people leave the

[00:59:42] state than move in. And a few months ago, Virginia lost its number one spot in CNBC's annual top state for business rankings. And CNBC was clear about one major factor, federal job cuts that were disproportionately harming Virginia's economy. The chaos coming out of Washington, it's not just bad policy, it's doing real damage to Virginia families and to Virginia businesses.

[01:00:07] They aren't just federal workers, they're Virginians whose livelihoods depended on the stable federal workforce. People working in manufacturing, food service, and contracting. Our economy is also still recovering from the longest federal government shutdown in history, A time when so many of our

fellow Virginians were anxious about the possibility of more mass firings and the threat of withheld paychecks.

[01:00:35] On day one, I ordered the creation of Virginia's Economic Resiliency Task Force, which will coordinate our statewide response to federal funding cuts, lost research dollars, tariffs, the ongoing impact of DOGE, and more. Among its jobs will be to finally gather a full picture of the economic damage done to our Commonwealth and then recommend measures that we can take right now to slow down the long-term impacts. That is the responsible thing to do for our Commonwealth. To Virginia's federal workers who have been laid off, furloughed, or are simply caught in the political headwinds of the moment,

[01:01:15] Hear me when I say, as your governor, I will direct the full power of the office to support you, support Virginia's economy, and support the federal workforce who call Virginia home. That's why our Economic Resiliency Task Force will also focus on expanding job placement

[01:01:54] and public-private partnerships for displaced federal workers and contractors. They're real people facing real challenges, and if some leaders in Washington won't fight for them. Leaders in Richmond must. And it's not just federal job cuts hurting our economy.

[01:02:28] Current trade policies are doing real harm. And no one is feeling it more than Virginia's farmers and rural communities. Agriculture is Virginia's largest private industry. Our farmers feed our families, steward our land, and anchor communities across Virginia. They deserve a government that fights for them, not one that makes their lives harder with unpredictable tariffs and chaotic trade wars, driving up input costs and eliminating entire markets for their products.

[01:03:03] Cargo traffic at the Port of Virginia is already down 9 percent. That tells a story of broader struggles for our farmers trying to get their products to market, for our forestry industry, for businesses large and small across the Commonwealth.

[01:03:20] With that, I have directed our Secretary of Commerce and Trade, Carrie Chenery, and our Secretary of Agriculture and Forestry, Katie Frazier, to work together in a coordinated

[01:03:32] effort to help Virginia's farmers and producers expand their reach, domestically and internationally.

[01:04:05] To make sure that communities across rural Virginia and all of Virginia can reap the benefits of trade. I will always work as governor to maintain a stable, predictable business climate for Virginia's employers, employees, and communities. I will be responsible and a good steward of every tax dollar entrusted to us working to protect our AAA bond rating.

[01:04:28] That is my commitment. It has done their national rankings 18 times, and Virginia has been in the top three, 11 of those times, under governors from both parties.

[01:05:00] When we get the fundamentals right, Virginia wins. Our job now is to put ourselves in a position to reclaim the top spot and to stay there.

[01:05:21] I want to acknowledge Governor Youngkin's meaningful work on economic development, particularly on shovel-ready sites and positioning Virginia for investment.

[01:05:38] His administration and the Virginia Economic Development Partnership deserve credit, And now our task is to build upon the progress and work that has been done. That means investing in our

workforce.

[01:06:06] It means expanding apprenticeship and paid internship programs. It means strengthening programs like G3 and Fast Forward that help Virginians earn credentials in high-demand fields. It means aligning our community colleges with employer needs.

[01:06:22] and recognizing that right now Virginia invests less per community college student than our neighbors in West Virginia and North Carolina. We can do better. And it means supporting our veterans as they transition to civilian careers. We have an unmatched tradition of military service

[01:06:58] here in Virginia. We are home to more than 700,000 veterans, many in the room here today. And we are home to some of the most important military installations in the world. The patriotic individuals who currently serve or who have previously served have demonstrated leadership, discipline, and a commitment to mission that any employer would want within their workforce.

[01:07:26] Our administration will work to expand apprenticeship programs, will streamline credentialing, and ensure that military experience translates to civilian licenses. I will work to connect veterans with employers who both understand their skill set and who truly

[01:08:02] understand their value. I also want to speak about public safety. It's an issue near and dear to my heart. You might know that I come from a law enforcement family. My dad spent his career as a federal agent and I served as a federal agent and later a CIA case officer. I understand the sacrifices and the risks that those who dedicate their lives to public safety face. And we cannot build a thriving economy without safe communities. But frankly, too many of our law enforcement officers, firefighters, first responders are being priced out of the very communities that they

[01:08:39] protect and serve. If we are asking someone to risk their life for their community, the least we can do is ensure that they can afford to live in it. My administration will support public servants with investments in recruitment, retention, training, and the mental health resources that they deserve.

[01:09:16] We will work collaboratively with communities to keep every Virginian safe regardless of their zip code.

[01:09:38] Public safety, workforce development, lowering costs in housing, healthcare, and energy, these are the building blocks of a thriving economy. So let me address one more economic issue directly, because I think businesses of all sizes need clarity, they need predictability, and they need to know the rules will not suddenly change on them.

[01:09:57] As I said along the campaign trail, I will not repeal Virginia's right to work status. But, my friends, I want to be really direct about something.

[01:10:22] Being pro-business and being pro-worker are not mutually exclusive. Recent history shows that Virginia's economic success has always come from balancing both.

[01:10:51] We can support business growth and invest in our workforce. We can attract new companies and protect workers. We can be the best state for business and the best state for working families. It is not an either-or proposition. It's just hard to get right, but we will here in the Commonwealth.

[01:11:12] That is why we will create a statewide paid family and medical leave program.

[01:11:33] It's why we'll guarantee paid sick days, increase access to Virginia's child care subsidy program, and yes, at long last, raise our minimum wage to $15 an hour.

[01:12:02] If you work full-time in Virginia, you should be able to afford to live in Virginia.

[01:12:28] We can do all of this. We can balance these forces. We've done it before. we can do it again. And if we do, Virginia will be the best state for talent in America.

[01:12:57] Here's the challenge. We cannot achieve these economic goals and attract talent if we don't take a hard look at our investments in education. The workforce of tomorrow is sitting in our

[01:13:31] classrooms today. I am the proud product of Virginia Public Schools. My husband, Adam, I are the parents of three daughters in Virginia public schools. We believe deeply in public education. And as governor, I will work every day to make sure our schools are the best in the United

[01:13:54] States of America. And it starts with having the best teachers across the Commonwealth. We are consistently asking our teachers, our educators to do more with less. And we, Virginia, we are paying

[01:14:27] our teachers below the national average. If we want to recruit, retain, and support public educators, we need to pay them more, period. We also need to focus on getting back to the basics

[01:15:03] in the classroom. Last year, Virginia students ranked 51st in the nation for math recovery, dead last, behind every other state and the District of Columbia. That is completely unacceptable. Immediately after becoming governor, I signed an executive order to promote academic excellence.

[01:15:24] I have directed the Virginia Department of Education to strengthen our core instructional systems, including in reading and math.

[01:15:49] And I have ordered the department to expand our efforts in advanced math instruction so that we can get our kids back on track and then help them get ahead. And the only way we're going to improve student performance is if parents and educators are partners working together to help students succeed.

[01:16:25] Let me be clear. My administration will not use our students, our parents, or our teachers as political pawns in an ongoing culture war. Working together to achieve better educational outcomes has always been a two-way street.

[01:17:00] Putting parents and teachers against each other won't work. It never has. and on the topic of education there is one issue that consistently unites virginians no matter their political leanings it is the notion that every child deserves to learn without fear gun violence is the number one cause of death for children and teens in the united states of america the number one cause of death for our children it is a horrifying fact and it is one that should motivate every one of us in this chamber

[01:17:37] to ask, "What can we do to change that?" I grew up in a family where responsible gun ownership was the norm. My dad went to work with a gun on his hip every single day. We had guns in the house. My uncle was an avid hunter.

[01:17:52] As a federal agent myself, I carried a firearm every day as part of my job. I respect the Second Amendment, and don't let anyone tell you otherwise.

[01:18:14] I also know that we can take common-sense steps to keep our families, our communities, kids and law enforcement safe.

[01:18:43] Over the last four years, dozens of gun safety bills have been vetoed, many which passed the General Assembly with bipartisan support. This includes legislation that would ban ghost guns, restrict access to firearms for convicted domestic abusers, and strengthen red flag laws for those who might be a danger to themselves or others.

[01:19:10] These are common sense measures supported by an overwhelming majority of Virginians, the very voters who sent us all here. Virginia is ready to make our communities safer, and I am ready to sign these bills.

[01:19:25] Please send them to my desk.

[01:19:51] Word on higher education: Virginia has some of the finest colleges and universities in the world.

[01:20:14] And yet, news story after news story, it's not about their successes. It's about them becoming political battlegrounds. Our students deserve better, our educators deserve better, our institutions deserve better, our economy and our Virginia deserve better, and this ends right now.

[01:20:51] Through executive order, I have directed the Department of Education under the leadership of Secretary of Education, Dr. Jeffrey Smith, to work alongside the Secretary of the Commonwealth,

[01:21:20] Munden King, to review and evaluate the process for appointments to our Higher Education Boards of Visitors. And I will work with this General Assembly to pursue reforms that prevent any future

[01:21:57] governor, Democrat or Republican, from imposing an ideological agenda on our universities.

[01:22:20] Governor, I have already and I will continue to appoint serious mission-driven individuals to serve our boards of visitors, people whose allegiance is to the institutions they are serving, not any political agenda.

[01:22:57] On Saturday, I was proud to fill vacancies on the boards of UVA, VMI, and George Mason, and now I entrust those individuals to do right by the universities they are going to serve and the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[01:23:14] And I welcome anyone in the room. If you have additional suggestions for folks to be appointed to boards, I will redirect you to Secretary of the Commonwealth Candy Munden King. Now, we have a few amendments on their way to the people of Virginia for final approval at the ballot box.

[01:23:49] First, the amendment on reproductive freedom. is now the only state in the South where a woman has the same freedom to make her own health care decisions as she did the day of the fall of Roe versus Wade. Let's speak plainly about what's going on in states with bans on reproductive health care, abortion services, and fertility treatment. Women facing medical emergencies are being turned away from hospitals and some of them

[01:24:22] have died. Virginia will not fall victim to this, and the women of Virginia will not die

[01:24:30] because their doctors are afraid to provide care. I trust Virginia women, I trust Virginia families, I trust Virginia doctors, and politicians should not dictate decisions for doctors and their

[01:25:09] patients. And now this constitutional amendment to protect fundamental reproductive freedom in Virginia will go to the voters, and I know they will support it, too. Next, we have an amendment on marriage equality. Marriage equality has been the law of the land in the United States of

America for over a decade. And yet, in Virginia's most sacred legal document, our Constitution, it still has discriminatory language from an earlier era. It is time to remove it.

[01:25:46] Every citizen of this commonwealth should rest assured that they can marry the person they love, that their union is recognized and protected equally under the law, and that their family is just as valid as any other, and our Constitution should say the same.

[01:26:25] We have an amendment on the restoration of voting rights.

[01:26:46] Virginia is one of only two states that permanently strip voting rights from citizens for certain convictions, leaving the restoration of rights entirely to the discretion of one person, the governor.

[01:27:03] It's a shameful relic of our Jim Crow past, and it is time to change it. It's worth noting that governors of both parties have worked on this issue over the last two decades.

[01:27:42] Most notably, Governors Bob McDonnell and Terry McAuliffe. Between the two of them, they restored the rights of tens of thousands of Virginians who served their time, rejoined our communities, and deserved the right to participate in the most fundamental act an engaged citizen can take, the right to cast a ballot.

[01:28:06] I thank the General Assembly for passing this constitutional amendment to automatically restore voting rights for Virginians and who have completed their sentences. And so let me say something broader about voting in Virginia.

[01:28:22] Virginia has not always been at the forefront of voting rights. Our history includes poll taxes, literary tests, literacy tests, and deliberate efforts to keep citizens from the ballot box. But look how far that we have come in the past few years.

[01:28:39] Expanded early voting, no-excuse absentee voting, automatic voter registration, Election Day is a holiday in the state, and we passed the Virginia Voting Rights Act. I believe that our democracy is strongest when every eligible citizen can participate and when our decisions reflect the will of the people.

[01:29:03] And in that spirit, as we protect reproductive rights, marriage rights, and voting rights, we must be ready to contend with further attacks on our democratic institutions across the country. Now, I know the General Assembly just took a step forward in being prepared to respond to what is happening in other states. Virginia's proposed redistricting amendment is a response to what we're seeing in other states that have taken extreme measures to undermine democratic norms. This approach here in Virginia is short-term, highly targeted, and completely

[01:29:41] dependent on what other states decide to do themselves. And for those who may oppose Virginia's response, I call on you to make your opposition to what is happening in other states

[01:29:54] clear. No mistake. Virginia will be responsive and targeted and only with the will of the people.

[01:30:31] And I trust the voters to get this one right. As you all know, trust is the most important currency that we have in public life. And on that topic, I'd like to say a word about how I intend to work with the federal government over the next four years. I believe the governor of Virginia and the president of the United States should have a productive relationship built on mutual trust.

[01:31:01] We are neighbors after all. And let me say here today that where there are shared priorities, I will actively seek and be ready for partnership. I want Virginia to lead the way. But I also have a

responsibility to the 8.8 million people who call Virginia home. So when federal actions attack and threaten Virginia jobs, I will not hesitate to push back. When federal chaos creates uncertainty for Virginia families, I will work to provide stability. When Washington fails to lead with

[01:31:37] dignity and respect and follow the rule of law Virginia will. Above all else, my job as governor is to provide what the federal government too often has not. Predictability, steadiness, and an

[01:31:53] unrelenting focus on the people we serve. I want to close. We're getting close. I want to close by reflecting on why we are here this afternoon. Not just in this chamber, but on this day. This day of

[01:32:32] reflection, and service. We gather on a day when Virginians and all Americans honor the legacy of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. If you'll indulge me, I want to share a story about Dr. King that has stayed with me. In January of 1957, Dr. King was just 28 years old when he was helping lead the Montgomery bus boycotts. And one morning, 12 sticks of dynamite were found on his front porch.

[01:32:59] The fuses had been lit and then smoldered out before they could detonate. Authorities believe the segregationists who put them there wanted the evidence to be found. A message of intimidation. The next morning, Dr. King delivered a sermon, and for the first time, he publicly shared a spiritual experience he'd had a year earlier, after a threatening late-night phone call had left him sitting alone at his kitchen table.

[01:33:26] He said an internal voice, in his words, quote, almost coming out of nowhere, told him, stand up for the truth, stand up for righteousness. And since that epiphany, he said he can, quote, stand up without fear.

[01:33:44] Dr. King did not demonize. He did not dehumanize. He fought for his cause while still seeing the humanity in everyone. That is the model of leadership we should all strive to follow. because our collective work, it's not just about policy. It is about our approach to governance.

[01:34:05] If we are going to tackle the challenges before us, and there are many, we need to work together. My fellow Virginians, I am not naive about the state of our politics in 2026. The temperature has risen in Virginia and across the country, and too often we have seen what happens when rhetoric turns reckless, when disagreement hardens into distrust, and when we forget that the people on the other side of an argument are still our neighbors.

[01:34:37] So let me say this clearly to everyone in this chamber and to everyone watching at home. Threats and intimidation have no place in Virginia. Political violence has no place in Virginia against anyone for any reason.

[01:34:53] Disabilization, harassment, and the politics of cruelty have no place in our commonwealth.

[01:35:27] We can disagree and we will disagree. That is the nature of democracy. But disagreement need not mean contempt. And Virginia can model something different for the rest of the nation, not by pretending that our disagreements do not exist, but by proving that they can be navigated with seriousness, with respect, and with good faith. Before anything else, we are Virginians and we can be an example for the rest of the country and the rest of the world. So in that spirit, let me answer

[01:36:01] the question that I was asked to address today. What is the state of our commonwealth? I believe that the state of our commonwealth depends on whether we show up for each other, not just in this chamber, but in our neighborhoods, our schools, our places of worship, and our communities. It It

depends on whether we endeavor to find common cause and whether we put the communities we serve ahead of the politics that divide us.

[01:36:31] If we put Virginia first, then I can say with confidence that the state of our commonwealth is and will be stronger, more prosperous, and more united than ever before. But there is work ahead. In November, voters sent us here with a clear message: work together, deliver results.

[01:37:10] I heard that message and I hope you did too. At a time of deep division, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. reminded us to stand up for truth, to stand up for righteousness, and to do so without fear. To every member of this General Assembly, let us rise to this moment.

[01:37:29] Let us stand up for the families who are counting on us. Let us stand up for the future that we can build together. Let us stand up for the Commonwealth that we love. Let's deliver for the people who have sent us here.

[01:37:41] you so very much Virginia and thank you to the members of the General Assembly. General Assembly

[01:39:39] will come, no I'm sorry, the Joint Assembly, all of y'all will come to order, back to order. The Senator from Mecklenburg, Senator Mulcahy, this, oh she's here. As many as favor the motion will say aye. Those opposed will say no. The motion is agreed to. The Senator from Richmond City, Senator

[01:40:11] Jones. As many as favor the motion will say aye. Those opposed no. The motion is agreed to. The Join the assembly as adjourned, signing down. I would ask, I would ask, I would ask, I would ask that all House members and guests remain seated as the Senate exits the chamber.

[01:40:41] All House members and guests remain seated as the Senate exits the chamber.

[01:41:04] Again, House members, please remain seated as I request that our distinguished guests on the floor and in the gallery now depart the chamber.

[01:41:34] House will come to order. Does the clerk have any announcements?

[01:42:33] Speaker, no. I've already announced the schedule for tomorrow. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourns to reconvene tomorrow at 12:00 noon. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that when the House adjourns today, it adjourns to reconvene tomorrow at 12:00 noon.

[01:42:48] As many as favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that the House do now adjourn. As many as favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands adjourned until tomorrow at 12:00 noon.



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